Me: You know, Rahul ji, about 353 girls are going to die when they see you put your arm around my shoulder.

Rahul: Why? *[He asked innocently.]*

Me: Because of jealousy.

Rahul: *[Bringing me closer.]* Really ... Okay, then, let's give them something more … *[I had a big grin on my face throughout most of the conversation that followed.)*

Me: Why are you walking?

Rahul: Do you know the difference between pooja and tapasya?

Me: Yes, pooja is worship and tapasya is penance.

Rahul: Tapasya comes from the word 'tapp', which means heat. When you do tapasya, you generate heat. The heat that consumes you. It hurts you, it pains you and then you achieve.

Me: But what do you hope to achieve?

Rahul: Your love, your blessings, our unity.

Me: There could have been other ways.

Rahul: Yes. Sure. But I do not want to achieve anything without putting in an effort, without doing tapp. Unless it hurts me, pains me, any achievement is not worth it. This is my tapasya.

Me: And I am sure you will achieve it.

Rahul: One has to do tapasya without expectations, and only then will it be successful. I don't know whether I will achieve what I have set out to do, but I will keep burning myself until I do.

Me: How do we ordinary common folk deal with the hate narrative being spread?

Rahul: The RSS and BJP are dangerous—they want to control you through fear. And for fear they use religion. Tell me something, what are you?